ment Department, not Industry.

"I don't think they have understood its import," counters National Conference spokesperson Imran Nabi Dar. "People in J&K have always wanted red tape to go." In a place less endowed with fragile beauty, the bill's promise of a "transparent, rule-based" framework could have itself sounded beautiful. It's action-oriented, with Section 11 setting a stopwatch: three working days for new enterprises in approved industrial parks or zones, 30 outside them, 45 for existing enterprises. If a decision fails to arrive in time, the licence et al are deemed granted. It also eliminates multiple NOCs, introduces self- and third-party certifications, and cuts inspections.

WIDE POWERS FOR OMAR

One source of discomfort is concentration of powers. A three-tier structure is envisaged: an Ease of Doing Business Council chaired by the CM, an executive committee headed by the chief secretary, and district empowered committees. The Council serves as the appellate body and frames rules. Section 18 gives the CM wide powers to override laws restricting construction and land-use, particularly farm and horticulture land conversion. To "encourage enterprises, particularly MSMEs", it says, norms shall be eased "to the extent possible".

The critics validate the intent as "legitimate and necessary"—but warn of a failure to distinguish between "necessary reform" and a statutory free-for-all. "We do need a regulatory environment that's transparent, predictable and free from delays," former J&K chief town planner Iftikhar Ahmad Hakim tells INDIA TODAY. "The distinction is between simplifying approvals and relaxing substantive rules...prepared through technical studies, land-use analysis and the like." Permission for enterprises outside industrial zones, Para warns, poses a danger to productive farmland and orchards. Citing the Valley's flood-prone mountainscape, Hakim sums it up in two lines: "Our land is a finite and irreplaceable resource. Loss may be irreversible." ■

▶ GUJARAT

FROM ROSES TO R

Straight out of a grim fairy tale, Bhetavada village battles



By **Jumana Shah**

THE VILLAGE ONCE GREW ROSES. Before dawn broke over Ahmedabad's markets, trucks dutifully left Bhetavada, in the district's Dholka taluka, like the bearers of a good omen. Laden with blooms still wet with dew, they spread like fragrance, making garlands of petalled roads around weddings and temples. Fifteen years later, the omen has darkened. Colour and fragrance have deserted Bhetavada. Its roses withered, its fields ruined, the village now counts its cancer cases. The only garlands it knows—and these appear all too often—are funereal.

For all its troubles, what it received in return was toxic sludge. For over a decade now, Bhetavada and the surrounding villages of Trasad, Nesda, Paldi and Ambareli have been dosed with untreated sewage from Dholka town. Some 18 million litres per day (mld), arriving in open drains that crisscross the villages like they're distributing manna. Villagers allege that pharmaceutical units in the vicinity also release their untreated chemical discharge into the sewage, so that it